

Community Pharmacy Selfcare Advice Service (CPSAS)

North East London (NEL) Integrated Care Board — Full Overview

1. Pharmacy First — National Background

- Pharmacy First is an advanced service which allows community pharmacists to provide advice and treatment.
- The service started on 31 January 2024 as a national service delivered through pharmacies.
- It builds on the previous NHS Community Pharmacist Consultation Service (CPCS).
- It is optional for pharmacies to provide, but ≥95% of pharmacies in England have signed up.
- In NEL, 364 out of 370 community pharmacies are providing Pharmacy First.

Pharmacy First is composed of three elements:

- **Minor illness** — low acuity minor illness referral / consultation.
- **Clinical Pathways** for 7 specific clinical conditions.
- **Urgent Medicines Supply**.

All referrals from GPs must be sent electronically through 'Local Services' on EMIS, or via PharmRefer. Access to the service is LIMITED if a patient is not referred through the integrated pathway (walk-ins accepted at the pharmacy's discretion for genuine minor illness, subject to the Clinical Pathway gateway criteria below).

2. Referral Pathway Logic

Referrals can originate from NHS 111 / an Urgent Care Centre (pathway in development), from a GP practice, or as a walk-in. GP referrals are routed electronically and triaged against two possible routes:

- **Low Acuity Minor Illness Referral** → Patient Consultation → assessed against CPSAS eligibility criteria (see Section 5). If met, the patient can receive free-of-charge OTC medicines from the approved formulary.
- **Clinical Pathway Consultation Referral** (used when the presentation meets the 'gateway' criteria for one of 7 specific conditions) → Patient Consultation under the relevant Clinical Pathway Patient Group Direction.

3. Pharmacy First — Clinical Pathways (7 Common Conditions)

These 7 conditions have dedicated national clinical pathways with defined age ranges, and are consistent across all ICBs in England:

Clinical Pathway	Age Range
Uncomplicated UTI	Women 16–64 years
Shingles	18 years and over
Impetigo	1 year and over
Infected Insect Bites	1 year and over
Sinusitis	12 years and over
Sore Throat	5 years and over
Acute Otitis Media	1–17 years

4. Pharmacy First — Examples of Minor Illness Referrals

This is NOT an exhaustive list — community pharmacies can receive referrals for anything considered a minor illness. General practice can refer for any of the presentations below (and others at clinical judgement):

Acne, spots, and pimples	Allergic reaction
Ankle or foot pain or swelling	Athlete's foot
Bites or stings (insect or spider)	Blisters
Constipation	Cough
Cold and flu	Diarrhoea
Ear discharge or ear wax	Earache
Eye, red	Eye, sticky or watery
Eyelid problems	Hair loss
Headache	Hearing problems or blocked ear
Hip, thigh, or buttock pain or swelling	Knee or lower leg pain
Lower back pain	Lower limb pain or swelling/itch
Mouth ulcers	Nasal congestion
Pain and/or frequency passing urine	Rectal pain
Scabies	Scratches and grazes
Shoulder pain	Skin blisters or rash
Sleep difficulties	Sore throat
Teething	Tiredness
Toe pain or swelling	Vaginal discharge
Vaginal itch or soreness	Vomiting
Wound problems — management of dressings	Wrist, hand, or finger pain or swelling

5. NEL Community Pharmacy Selfcare Advice Service (CPSAS) — Objectives

CPSAS is a 2-year, locally (NEL) commissioned community pharmacy service, launched 22 July 2024. Its main objectives are to:

- Complement and aid implementation of the nationally commissioned Pharmacy First service, providing free-of-charge OTC medicines for eligible patients.
- Help reduce health inequalities by removing the barrier of cost of medicines, and by providing targeted advice and support on health and wellbeing interventions.
- Give eligible residents access to timely advice and support on health and wellbeing.
- Reduce the number of GP appointments and/or A&E; attendances for conditions related to specific common minor illnesses.

Background: Health Inequalities and Deprivation in NEL

- Minor illnesses amenable to self-care are a significant proportion of primary care and A&E; attendances. People living in the most deprived areas often face barriers to accessing self-care advice and medicines.

- Approximately 24% of the NEL population (489,000 people) live in areas ranked in the most deprived 20% in England.
- As of March 2023, there were 5,644 asylum seekers in NEL. The boroughs with the highest numbers are Newham (27%) and Redbridge (21%).

Data source: Home Office — Immigration System Statistics (March 2023) and NEL Health & Care Partnership Population Health report (May 2022).

6. Access to the CPSAS

- CPSAS is available from 347 community pharmacies in North East London (out of 369/370 total).
- A list of community pharmacies NOT providing CPSAS is available on the ICB Medicines Portal.
- ALL patients MUST be referred by their GP to their local community pharmacy through the Pharmacy First referral route, via Local Services on EMIS or PharmRefer.
- Community pharmacies assess referred patients' eligibility. If the referral falls under one of the 24 specific minor illness conditions (Section 7), CPSAS can be provided: self-care advice, free-of-charge OTC medicines, and/or referral or signposting to other locally available services.
- There are no additional requirements for general practice beyond continuing to refer patients presenting with a minor illness condition to community pharmacy teams for Pharmacy First, via Local EMIS.
- Walk-ins for CPSAS are only permitted for patients who are Homeless, Asylum Seekers, or Refugees.

7. The 24 Conditions Covered by CPSAS

These are the specific minor illness conditions eligible for free-of-charge OTC medicines and self-care advice under CPSAS, once a patient has been GP-referred via EMIS Local Services / PharmRefer and assessed as eligible by the pharmacy:

#	Condition	#	Condition
1	Athlete's foot	13	Fever (pyrexia)
2	Insect bites and stings	14	Soft tissue injury
3	Back pain / musculoskeletal pain	15	Haemorrhoids
4	Nappy rash	16	Oral thrush
5	Conjunctivitis	17	Hay fever
6	Paediatric fever / teething / pain	18	Threadworm
7	Constipation	19	Headache
8	Primary dysmenorrhoea (period pain)	20	Toothache
9	Contact dermatitis	21	Head lice
10	Ringworm	22	Vaginal thrush
11	Diarrhoea	23	Indigestion / heartburn
12	Scabies	24	Warts and verrucae

Note: Conditions 1, 2, 6, 9, 12 and several others were newly added and were previously NOT covered by the City & Hackney Healthy Foundations Partnership (C&H; HFP) Minor Ailment Scheme — indicated in red font in the original ICB slide.

8. Patient Eligibility Criteria

Walk-in eligibility (no GP referral required)

- Only for patients who are Homeless, Asylum Seekers, or Refugees — whether or not registered with a GP practice, or registered with a NEL GP practice but unable to get an appointment.

Referred-patient eligibility (via GP)

- All referred patients must be registered with a NEL GP practice.

- Patients under 16 years, who have at least one parent who would be eligible for this service.
- Patients aged 16, 17 or 18, in full-time education, AND with at least one parent who would be eligible.
- All young people who are under the care of the Local Authority.
- Young care leavers, aged 16–25 years old.
- Patients receiving Universal Credit whose income is at a level making them eligible for free prescriptions; patients receiving any other low-income benefit that gives eligibility for free prescriptions.
- Patients who are Homeless, Asylum Seekers, or Refugees.
- Patients eligible for full help (HC2 certificate) under the NHS Low Income Scheme (LIS) — LIS eligibility also extends to the patient's partner and any young dependants.

9. Medicines Formulary

- Community pharmacies provide free-of-charge OTC medicines from the approved medicines formulary to eligible patients for the specific minor illnesses listed in Section 7.
- The formulary is pre-populated on the PharmOutcomes template according to the condition being treated.
- Patients may receive more than one medicine for a specific condition where clinically appropriate (e.g. loperamide plus oral rehydration salts for diarrhoea).
- Medicines are only supplied for infrequent minor illnesses. Requests for repeat supplies could indicate a long-term condition requiring investigation and management by the patient's GP.

10. CPSAS — Reducing Health Inequalities

- Facilitates community pharmacies to support self-care (advice, information, signposting, medication) for all NEL patients irrespective of financial means.
- Enables residents with financial difficulties to obtain free-of-charge OTC medicines where appropriate.
- Supports community pharmacists in making every contact count — signposting patients to other appropriate local or national services (e.g. blood pressure checks, smoking cessation, vaccination, sexual health, contraception) and to health & wellbeing resources.
- Community pharmacies have good knowledge of the local community and can support 'harder-to-reach' patient groups, e.g. those with language barriers.
- Highly accessible: pharmacies are closer to patients' and residents' homes; 347 of 369 community pharmacies in NEL currently provide this service.

11. Patient Poster

- A patient poster has been developed to publicise the new NEL CPSAS service, particularly aimed at those in the walk-in eligibility categories.
- The poster and translated versions are being disseminated to relevant organisations for display.

12. Further Information, Contacts & Queries

- Further information is available in the ICB Medicines Portal: 'Community Pharmacy Selfcare Advice Service – North East London' page, including a webinar, FAQ, and the list of community pharmacies not providing CPSAS.
- **Service queries/issues:** NEL ICB Medicines Optimisation team — nelondonicb.medicinesoptimisationenquiries@nhs.net

- **Compliments & complaints:** via the pharmacy provider's internal complaints procedure. Service-specific issues should be reported to NEL ICB (see 'Advice, compliments and complaints' on the NHS North East London ICB website).
- **Media/press enquiries:** should be directed to the NEL ICB communications team — nelondon.nelcommunications@nhs.net or nelcsu.media@nhs.net

Source: 'Community Pharmacy Selfcare Advice Service (CPSAS) Overview', NHS North East London ICB (primarycare.northeastlondon.icb.nhs.uk). Compiled and reformatted for reference use.